desperately to pull his bat inside after the fact, as if to dispel what he has just done.

Clouds then come over the ground, like a gift from above, with the Australians teetering at 37-3, the formations hovering low and suggesting the ball might swing. Strauss sees them and, answering the call as if the weather was asking for something itself, urging him to give me the ball, he pulls me back into the attack. Mike Hussey is in. He's the vital wicket this series, averaging close to 70. I run in, visualising the ball that angles across him, forces him to play, and he edges behind. It all falls out of the sky exactly as I have imagined it. He's gone. My arms are outstretched, all inhibitions gone, screaming into the Australian summer. Then Steve Smith is in my sights. My plan for him is to bowl the same ball as many times as I can, the one outside off stump that leaves him in no man's land, and wait for the pitch to help me out, the ball to move off it or an error of judgement. I get one to just kick outside off stump, his shot already offered, unretractable, as he edges behind to Matt Prior. Michael Clarke is the same too. The almost exact same dismissal. It's all so easy, all so aligned, so synchronised. There is no trace of a time when I felt like I couldn't play cricket any more, like I wasn't good enough to do it, chased around by a black cloud in my home through that year in 2006. As we roll through them, wickets turning into other wickets, momentum becoming its own momentum, the MCG feels like it has shrunk and shrunk. We bowl them out for 98 just inside three hours.

It was odd to be inside unprecedented territory, but to also feel the overwhelming inevitability of it all. I watch Strauss and Cook pad up, the dressing room giddy with what has just happened out there, the coliseum of Australian cricket hushed on its marquee day. I know they will bat all day. Some sort of order has been established which is unbreakable. We are 157-0 at the close, eventually walking off a deserted MCG. The fans have not even lasted the whole day. It's the surest sign of victory you could imagine. After play, I'm trying not to smile too much when the Australian cricket coverage begrudgingly asks me, as if genuinely curious, 'You seem to have matured a hell of a lot since you've been here. What's happened?' I know what they mean. There are no words that will satisfy the time travelled between then and now.